PRELUDE XV

THE long notes sing best against very light finger-*staccato* semiquavers and *legato* quavers, especially as the one in bars 4-7 arises from a note which cannot bear an accent. Later quavers, especially when disjunct, may be *staccato* if desired, but not where their melodic interest is conspicuous. Sing them before you make up your mind how to play them. The turns (~) and mordents (ψ) are possible at quite a lively pace, but not at a *prestissimo*. Bars 14-15 and 46-47 should be decidedly melodious (with no suspicion of finger-*staccato*), but the general *tempo* may permissibly be fast enough to require a slight humouring in these places. In bars 37-40 the finger-*staccato* may be abandoned for a close touch admitting a darkening *crescendo* which, however, must not be allowed to become formidable, since the tonic recapitulation from bar 43 to the end admits no more emphasis than the original statement of bars 11-16.

FUGUE XV

THE quavers should be not much faster than the crotchets of the Prelude. In its present and final form this Fughetta (the lightest in all Bach's mature works) has two special features: first the exquisite key-board harmony-melody which accompanies the third and later entries of the Subject (bars 15-20); and secondly, the descending climax on a dominant pedal (bars 56-64), leading with an uprush of demisemiquavers to the final entry with its graceful coda. In the earliest versions of this Fughetta there was literally no counterpoint, the accompaniments consisting of homophonic quaver chords often making a mass of four-part harmony, while there was no middle voice entry after the Exposition. Now the final entry, being in the middle voice, completes the tiny but brilliant scheme, inasmuch as there has been, since the Exposition, just one entry in the bass (bar 33) answered by one in the treble (bar 40). As to the peculiar two-part Countersubject, in which neither part has complete melodic or rhythmic sense without the other while their sustained notes produce the harmonic sense, it stands the test of turning inside out as a Triple Counterpoint in bars 40-45. The real entries of the Subject in bars 33 and 40 may be led up to, but not masked by, a *crescendo* in the previous episodic sequences on the first two bars; (from bar 28 to bar 32.)

By far the best plan for the touch throughout this Fugue is to take the Subject in a brilliant *staccato* down to the first note of bar 6, which should initiate a quiet *legato*, to be observed wherever that conjunct link-figure appears. None of the quavers should be more than slightly detached, and the two-part harmony-counterpoint should, of course, be *legatissimo*. It will then sing very happily over the *staccato arpeggios*, and the effect of the last entry (bars 65-69) will be unapproachable by any other means. Though this method may at first seem paradoxical to some pianists, it would be self-evident to a string trio. The shakes in bars 50 and 52 stop on the third beat of the bar. The reading B♮ at the beginning of bar 60 is of high authority and may be a late improvement. It implies a slight broadening of the rhythm, so as to space out the modulation more than the simpler reading.

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